



GardenMD Quick Reference Guide

Diagnose fast. Plant on time.

Two printable references pulled straight from thegardenmd.com: a fast first-check for the most common garden symptoms, and a frost-date-relative seed starting calendar for common vegetables. Both are sourced from university extension research — see thegardenmd.com/sources for citations.

Diagnose It Fast

Start with the symptom you can actually see, check the most likely cause first, and confirm before you treat.

Symptom	Most Likely Cause	Check This First
Yellow leaves	Overwatering (94%)	Is soil still damp 2+ inches down, several days after watering?
Wilting	Underwatering (85%)	Check soil moisture at the root zone before assuming disease.
Brown leaf tips/edges	Leaf scorch or low indoor humidity	Recent heat, wind, missed watering, or dry heating-season air?
White powder on leaves	Powdery mildew (95%)	Check for crowded growth limiting airflow.
Black spots on leaves	Black spot fungus (88%)	Dark spots with feathered edges, ringed by yellowing?
Roots out of the pot	Root-bound plant	Does water run straight through without soaking in?
Small flies near soil	Fungus gnats (88%)	Has the top inch of soil stayed damp for several days?

Full diagnostic pages with confirmation steps and sourced fixes: thegardenmd.com/diagnose

Seed Starting Calendar

Timed relative to your last spring frost date, since the exact calendar date varies by climate. Get your date from your local extension office or NOAA climate normals.

Crop	Start Indoors	Move Outside	Method
Tomatoes	6-8 wks before frost	1-2 wks after frost	Transplant

Peppers	8-10 wks before frost	2-3 wks after frost	Transplant
Basil	6-8 wks before frost	1-2 wks after frost	Transplant
Cucumbers	3-4 wks before frost	1-2 wks after frost	Direct sow
Zucchini	3-4 wks before frost	1-2 wks after frost	Direct sow
Beans	Not started indoors	1-2 wks after frost	Direct sow
Peas	Not started indoors	4-6 wks before frost	Direct sow
Lettuce	4-6 wks before frost	2-4 wks before frost	Direct sow/transplant
Spinach	Not started indoors	4-6 wks before frost	Direct sow
Carrots	Not started indoors	2-4 wks before frost	Direct sow

Interactive calculator (enter your exact frost date for real dates): thegardenmd.com/calculators/seed-starting-calculator